



THE BABRI MASJID
DEMOLITION

DELHI | Better Late Than Never

When Justice (retired) M.S. Liberhan submitted his report to Prime Minister Manmohan Singh on June 30, it ended the inquiry into the December 6, 1992 demolition of the Babri Masjid at Ayodhya. The chief of the Liberhan Commission felt “free and independent” after handing over his report. Justice Liberhan will now be remembered for chairing the longest-ever commission of inquiry in India’s history. The BJP reacted with President Rajnath Singh slamming the commission for the delay on a “sensitive issue of national interest”. Sources hinted at “enough evidence” in the report to nail senior BJP leaders. It took the one-man panel 17 years and 48 extensions to probe into the events leading to the demolition of the mosque. Justice Liberhan faced his biggest challenge—the credibility of his report—when the counsel attached to the commission fell out with him two years ago, claiming that the retired judge did not seem keen to address BJP leader L.K. Advani’s role in the demolition. During the inquiry, Liberhan had questioned Advani and other BJP leaders, including Murli Manohar Joshi, then Uttar Pradesh chief minister Kalyan Singh and Uma Bharati. Appointed by then prime minister P.V. Narasimha Rao on December 16, 1992, the commission had over 400 sittings and spent Rs 10 crore before reaching its denouement.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

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years and 48 extensions the Liberhan Commission took to submit its report on the Babri Masjid demolition.